

15 Questions Every Parent Should Ask About Their Child's Screen Habits



A Practical Checklist for Healthy Technology,
AI & Screen Habits.

An evidence-based, age-appropriate checklist to help families and schools support healthy, confident, and responsible technology use — not by restricting freedom, but by building digital wisdom.

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Based on published guidelines from AAP, WHO, APA, NCERT & NEP 2020



For Parents & Teachers: This checklist is a developmental guide, not a set of rules. Every child is different. Use it as a conversation starter, not a report card.

For Students: This exists because you matter. Technology is powerful, and so are you. The smartest digital citizens know how to use it on their own terms.

Grades 3–5 | Ages 8–10 | Explorers

Children at this stage are curious and trusting. They need guided exploration with clear guardrails.

? Layer 1: Developmental Readiness

Can your child do these things? If not, they may need more supervised access for now.

- ☐ Can explain, in simple words, why some websites and apps ask for their name, age, or school
- ☐ Understands that people online may not be who they say they are
- ☐ Comes to a trusted adult when something online makes them uncomfortable or scared
- ☐ Understands that anything shared online — photos, messages, videos — can stay online permanently
- ☐ Can follow time-based rules (e.g., "30 minutes of screen time") without repeated reminders
- ☐ Knows the difference between an advertisement and real content
- ☐ Can describe at least one example of unkind behaviour online and explain why it is wrong

✓ Layer 2: Healthy Use Guidelines

Practical habits that build digital confidence without over-dependence.

- ☐ Screen time: Limit recreational screen time to 1–2 hours/day (AAP). Homework is separate.
- ☐ Device location: All devices used in common family areas — not in bedrooms after bedtime.
- ☐ Co-viewing: Watch, play, and explore together. Ask what they enjoyed. This builds trust.
- ☐ No personal social media accounts. All major platforms require users to be 13+.
- ☐ Parental controls active on all devices. Explain why: "These keep you safe, like a seatbelt."
- ☐ Passwords are private. Never share passwords with friends — only with parents.
- ☐ Balance screen time with physical activity, reading, creative play, and family time daily.
- ☐ No devices during meals — this applies to adults too. Children learn from what they see.

🛠️ AI Tools (ChatGPT, Copilot, Gemini, Claude, etc.)

- ☐ AI tools should only be used with adult supervision at this age
- ☐ Teach children that AI can be wrong — it is a tool, not a teacher
- ☐ Never enter personal information (name, school, address) into any AI tool
- ☐ Use AI as a learning companion: "Let's ask together and check if it's right"

⚠️ Layer 3: Red Flag Indicators

If you observe these patterns consistently, it may be time for a conversation — not a punishment.

- ☐ Becomes unusually anxious, angry, or tearful when a device is taken away
- ☐ Hides the screen or quickly switches apps when an adult walks by
- ☐ Sleep disruption — difficulty falling asleep, waking at night, tiredness linked to screen use
- ☐ Noticeable loss of interest in activities they previously enjoyed
- ☐ Talks about online "friends" or contacts that parents have never met
- ☐ Sudden, unexplained changes in mood or behaviour after using a device
- ☐ Reluctance or refusal to talk about what they do online
- ☐ Declining academic performance or loss of concentration in class

→ If you notice red flags, start with curiosity, not confrontation. "I've noticed you seem upset after using the tablet — can you help me understand?" works better than "What were you doing on that thing?"

Grades 6–9 | Ages 11–14 | Champions

Children at this stage seek autonomy, peer validation, and identity. They need more independence — with structure, conversations, and adult presence.

? Layer 1: Developmental Readiness

Before expanding digital independence, check whether your child can demonstrate these capabilities.

- ☐ Can critically evaluate online information — distinguishes between fact, opinion, and misinformation
- ☐ Understands the concept of a digital footprint — that today's post can affect tomorrow's opportunity
- ☐ Can resist peer pressure online: choosing not to forward a message, not joining a pile-on
- ☐ Understands consent in the digital context — does not share others' photos or info without permission
- ☐ Can recognise manipulation techniques: clickbait, phishing, emotional triggers
- ☐ Is willing to manage their own privacy settings — and understands why each setting matters
- ☐ Can explain what cyberbullying looks like and what to do if they experience or witness it
- ☐ Understands that free apps and games often profit from user data

✓ Layer 2: Healthy Use Guidelines

At this age, collaboration works better than control. Build the plan together.

- ☐ Create a family media plan together. When teens co-author the rules, they follow them.
- ☐ Screen time: Focus on balance — ensure tech doesn't crowd out sleep (8–10 hrs), activity (60 min/day), homework.
- ☐ No devices in bedrooms after bedtime. A family charging station eliminates late-night scrolling.
- ☐ Digital footprint conversations: Search your child's name together. "Would a future employer see this?"
- ☐ Gaming boundaries: Discuss in-app purchases before they happen. Review multiplayer chat settings.
- ☐ Teach reporting and blocking. Every platform has these tools. Using them is essential.

📱 Social Media: The Recommendation & The Reality

The recommendation: AAP, APA, and most platform ToS set 13 as the minimum. Many experts recommend 15–16.

The reality: Many children are already on social media. If yours is — guide more, restrict less:

- ☐ Review privacy settings together — set profiles to private, disable location sharing
- ☐ Periodically review follower/following lists: "Do you actually know all these people?"
- ☐ Discuss what they share and why — build judgment, not just rules
- ☐ Talk about the difference between online validation (likes) and real-world self-worth

🤖 AI Tools (ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude, Copilot, etc.)

AI tools are part of the landscape. Banning them won't work. Teaching smart use will.

- ☐ AI is a tool, not an authority. Verify answers against trusted sources.
- ☐ Academic integrity matters. Submitting AI work as your own is dishonest.
- ☐ Never share personal or sensitive information with any AI tool.
- ☐ AI-generated content is everywhere: deepfakes, synthetic images, cloned voices are real.

⚠️ Layer 3: Red Flag Indicators

Adolescence is naturally turbulent — but these patterns warrant a calm, caring conversation.

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| ☐ Secretive — password changes, clearing history | ☐ Multiple or hidden social media accounts |
| ☐ Dramatic mood shifts after phone use | ☐ Excessive app/game spending |
| ☐ Chronic sleep deprivation from late-night use | ☐ Sharing info/photos with people never met |
| ☐ Declining grades or withdrawal from activities | ☐ Withdrawal from family and friendships |
| ☐ Signs of cyberbullying (target or participant) | ☐ Mentions of self-harm, dares, or secret contacts |

→ **For teens especially:** Your goal is to be the person they come to — not the person they hide from. Stay calm, avoid "I told you so," and focus on solutions. A single trusted adult can change the outcome.

References & Guidelines

International Guidelines

American Academy of Pediatrics (AAP), Media Use Guidelines (2023) • World Health Organization (WHO), Screen Time & Physical Activity Recommendations • American Psychological Association (APA), Health Advisory on Social Media Use in Adolescence (2023) • UNICEF, Digital Literacy and Children's Rights Framework • OECD, AI and the Future of Skills in Education (2024)

India-Specific Guidelines

National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, digital literacy and critical thinking across all stages • National Curriculum Framework (NCF) 2023, integration of digital citizenship • NCERT, Guidelines on safe and responsible use of ICT in schools • CBSE Circular Skill-81/2025, Digital Citizenship as a skill subject (Code 913) • Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, 2023, parental consent requirements for children's data

For CBSE Schools: CBSE has directed schools to integrate digital citizenship education through its Skill Subject framework and Cyber Safety Pledge initiative. This checklist aligns with those directives and supports schools in meeting NEP 2020 compliance.

Forward to someone who can benefit with these skills!

Enrol them in COMPUDON Junior — India's leading digital citizenship championship for students in Grades 3–9.

Registrations Open



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